Peatland rewetting in Schleswig-Holstein

Where are the peat soils, how are they used, how much do they emit – and where would rewetting make the most sense?

Project report · status 27 October 2026 · Bonnie Winter

QGIS / open-source portfolio project · test area: Treene–Sorge lowland (≈ 304 km²) · developed with the help of an AI assistant (see 'Use of AI', chapter 2)

The project in one paragraph. Drained peat soils under farmland are among the largest greenhouse-gas sources in Schleswig-Holstein. The project maps them for a test area, estimates their emissions from national emission factors, tests how robust that estimate is, derives hydrological sub-catchments from a 1 m terrain model, and then uses integer optimisation to find where a CO2 saving target can be reached with the least collateral damage. The central result: if rewetting is planned field by field, it looks efficient but would in reality wet thousands of hectares of farmland on mineral soil; planned by whole sub-catchments, the same target is reached with almost none. A comparison with the Prussian survey of 1878–80 shows that most of today's peat was already wet land then – and that about a third of the former wet meadows have since lost most of their peat.

Key numbers

	Value	Comment
Test area	30,358 ha	hand-drawn polygon, 34 municipalities
Organic soils	15,952 ha (53 %)	Thünen map (Wittnebel et al. 2023)
of it farmed	11,102 ha	97 % permanent grassland, 278 ha cropland
Current emissions	≈ 354,000 t CO2-eq/yr	ESTIMATE: area × national factor
Saving if all were rewetted	≈ 293,000 t CO2-eq/yr	rewetted peat still emits 5.5 t/ha
Uncertainty (90 % range)	351,000 – 358,000 t … 144,000 – 487,000 t	fields deviating independently … the whole region deviating together
Mineral-soil farmland wetted	4,512 ha (best parcel plan) vs 44 ha (catchment plan)	target 75,000 t CO2-eq/yr (≈ ¼ of the potential)
Wet land 1878–80 still organic today	88 % (whole area), 92 % (block)	1880 map read automatically, 93 % ± 4 % accuracy (blind check)
Chosen sub-catchments wet in 1880	68 % of their area (other candidates: 40 %)	step 07 knew nothing about 1880

Status

Step	Content	Status
00–04	inputs, overlay, emission estimate	done
01, 05	DGM1 download (355 tiles), hydrology with GRASS, stream burning	done
07, 07b	optimisation: parcels vs. catchments; the 1880 map per sub-catchment	done
08	Monte Carlo uncertainty	done
09	atlas: 24 A4 pages, one per municipality	done
06	historical wet land 1878–80 vs. today (36 km² block)	done
–	README, GitHub repository (MIT licence)	done
06x–06v	automated reading of the 1880 map, two training rounds, accuracy check	done

Contents

1	Question, context and study area
2	How the project is built (repository, configuration, software)
3	Data and licences
4	The analysis, step by step (00 → 09)
5	Main findings
6	Limitations of the whole approach
7	Problems encountered and how they were solved
8	Next steps
9	Glossary
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Every analysis step in chapter 4 is described in the same five parts: **why** it is needed, **what the script does**, the **results**, the **decisions** taken and why, and its **limitations**. All emission figures are estimates and are labelled as such.

1 Question, context and study area

The problem

Peat forms where water-logged conditions stop plant material from decomposing. Drained for farming, the peat is exposed to oxygen and slowly 'burns' away: the stored carbon is released as CO2, the ground subsides, and nitrous oxide is emitted as well. Raising the water table again (**rewetting**) stops most of this – but it also ends conventional farming on the land affected.

For Schleswig-Holstein, the Land's Moor-Klimaschutz information (January 2024) gives about 152,800 ha of carbon-rich soils (≈ 10 % of the state), of which about 129,800 ha peat (≈ 103,200 ha fen, 26,600 ha bog) and 23,000 ha Anmoor; more than 81 % are used for agriculture, and these soils cause about 17 % of the state's greenhouse-gas emissions.

The questions

- Where are the peat soils, and how are they used?
- How much do they emit – and how certain is that number?
- Which areas form their own hydrological unit, so that raising the water there does not flood neighbouring land?
- Where can a given CO2 saving be reached with the least land, the fewest units – or the least collateral damage?
- How much of today's peat was already wet land in the 1870s – and how much has been lost since? (step 06)

Study area (test mode)

I ran the analysis on a **test area** first, as in my earlier NRW project: a hand-drawn polygon of 30,358 ha (≈ 304 km²) in the Treene–Sorge lowland between Friedrichstadt, Hollingstedt and the A7, covering parts of the districts Schleswig-Flensburg, Nordfriesland and Rendsburg-Eckernförde (34 municipalities). I chose it because the Thünen map shows one of the densest concentrations of fen and bog soils in the state there. Setting `TEST_MODE = False` in the configuration would run everything for the whole state.

> **Key point.** The test area is a drawn polygon, not a real river catchment. That is fine for developing and checking the method, but it cuts through natural drainage units at its edges – step 05 flags those cut-off sub-catchments.

2 How the project is built

Repository structure

```
peatland-rewetting-sh/
├─ config.py            all paths, field names, parameters, emission factors
├─ peatsh/common.py     shared helpers: AOI, clipping, GeoPackage I/O, reports
├─ scripts/             00 … 09, one numbered script per analysis step
├─ qgis/                QGIS project peatland_sh.qgz, styles, models
├─ data/raw/            downloads, never edited          (not in git)
├─ data/interim/        DGM1 GeoTIFFs, hydrology rasters  (not in git)
├─ data/processed/      peatland_sh.gpkg – all results     (not in git)
├─ outputs/             CSV tables, figures, atlas maps
└─ docs/reports/        one short markdown report per step
```

Three design rules

- **One configuration file.** Nothing is hard-coded in the scripts. File paths, field names, emission factors, thresholds and the optimisation target live in `config.py`. Changing the study area or a factor means changing one line.
- **One GeoPackage for all vector results.** Every script reads and writes layers in `data/processed/peatland_sh.gpkg`, named `<step>_<area>` (e.g. `emissions_test_catchment`).
- **A report after every step.** Each script writes a markdown report with its numbers, the parameters used and the limitations – so every result can be traced back. Scripts refuse to run with missing inputs (e.g. no cited emission factor) instead of using made-up values.

Software

Tool	Used for	Note
QGIS 3.4x LTR (OSGeo4W Shell)	Python environment for all scripts	GeoPandas 1.1.3, GDAL, SciPy 1.17 already included
GeoPandas / pyogrio / Shapely	reading, reprojecting, clipping, overlay, gap closing	steps 00–04, 06–08
GDAL (osgeo)	XYZ → GeoTIFF, mosaic, resampling, vectorising	steps 01, 05
GRASS r.watershed via qgis_process	flow direction, accumulation, sub-catchments	step 05
SciPy milp (HiGHS solver)	binary integer optimisation	step 07
NumPy / SciPy / Matplotlib	Monte Carlo, distribution fitting, figure	step 08
PyQGIS	layer styling, print layout, atlas export	step 09, runs inside QGIS

Why not conda / WhiteboxTools / PuLP as originally planned? Windows *Smart App Control* on my computer blocks unsigned programs. It blocked the Miniforge (conda) installer and would also block the WhiteboxTools and CBC solver executables. QGIS and its bundled Python, GDAL and GRASS are signed, so I moved the whole pipeline onto QGIS's own Python. I also dropped PuLP because version 4.0 changed its interface. I deliberately left Smart App Control on: switching it off cannot be undone without reinstalling Windows.

Use of AI

I used an AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) throughout this project: to draft and debug the Python scripts, to explain methods and literature, to suggest approaches and to draft this report and the README. I defined the questions and the study area, downloaded and prepared the data, ran every script on my own computer, checked the results in QGIS, decided between the options for methods and parameters, and digitised the 1878–80 map by hand. All figures and maps in this report come from my own runs.

How to run

```
OSGeo4W Shell:
cd /d D:\PORTFOLIO\Peatlands\peatland-rewetting-sh\peatland-rewetting-sh
python scripts\00_check_inputs.py      (… then 01–08)
QGIS Python console (project qgis\peatland_sh.qgz open):
exec(open(r"…\scripts\09_export_maps_pyqgis.py", encoding="utf-8").read())
```

3 Data and licences

Dataset	Provider · licence	Used for	Notes
Aktualisierte Kulisse organischer Böden (Wittnebel, Frank, Tiemeyer 2023)	Thünen-Institut · CC BY 4.0	where the peat is; soil type	303,672 polygons, Germany; KAT_KURZ = soil category
Feldblöcke SH, reference date 1.1.2026	Land SH · dl-de/zero-2.0 (to confirm for 2026)	farmed land, arable vs. grassland	194,503 blocks; field HBN; CRS EPSG:4647
DGM1 (1 m terrain model)	LVermGeo SH, OpenGBD · CC BY 4.0	hydrology	XYZ text tiles 1×1 km; bulk-download index of 18,685 tiles
VG250 boundaries (state, districts, municipalities)	BKG · dl-de/by-2.0	statistics per municipality, atlas	fields GEN, AGS, SN_L, GF
Emission factors	Tiemeyer et al. 2020, Ecol. Indic. 109:105838	emission estimate, Monte Carlo	Table 5 (totals), Table 2 (ranges)
OpenStreetMap	© OSM contributors · ODbL	background maps	greyed in the atlas
Preußische Landesaufnahme 1878–80 (Chronologen WMS)	LVermGeo SH · CC BY 4.0	historical wet land (step 06)	layer Chronologen_1_1878-1880; digitised by hand
Zeichen-Erklärung für die Messtischblätter (1898)	Geobasis NRW reprint · free (dl-de/zero-2.0 recommended)	meaning of the 1880 map symbols	official key of the same survey series
Water-body network, ATKIS Basis-DLM (INSPIRE Hydro – Netzwerk, WFS)	LVermGeo SH · CC BY 4.0	stream burning (step 05)	1,885 km of lines in the test area
Protected areas (FFH, NSG)	LfU SH · to check	not used yet	–

Coordinate reference system

Everything is processed in **EPSG:25832** (ETRS89 / UTM zone 32N), the system of the LVermGeo SH data. The Feldblöcke arrive in **EPSG:4647**: the same projection, but with the zone number '32' written in front of the easting (32 500 000 instead of 500 000). The scripts reproject automatically.

Attribution required on every map

© GeoBasis-DE/LVermGeo SH/CC BY 4.0 (DGM1) · © GeoBasis-DE/BKG (VG250) · Thünen-Institut (organic soils) · Land Schleswig-Holstein (Feldblöcke) · © OpenStreetMap contributors. The atlas prints these in its footer.

4 The analysis, step by step

The order below follows the logic of the analysis, not the script numbers: data → overlay → emissions → uncertainty → hydrology → optimisation → maps.

Step 00 – Check inputs

Why

Before any analysis it must be clear what is actually in each file: its coordinate system, its attribute fields and their values. Field names differ between datasets and years, so they are looked up, not assumed.

What the script does

- lists every input in `config.INPUTS`: exists?, number of features, CRS, geometry type
- shows every attribute field with five example values
- reports how many DGM1 GeoTIFFs are present

Results (test area)

All main inputs were found. The report gave the field mapping now in the configuration: soil type **KAT_KURZ** (NH fen, HH bog, MF former peat soil, DK_* peat under a mineral cover), land use **HBN** (Ackerland / Dauergrünland), parcel ID **FLIK**.

Decisions and why

- Count features from the file header (pyogrio.read_info) instead of loading 300,000 polygons.
- Do not use the Feldblöcke field FLAECHE: it is text with a decimal comma. Areas are recomputed from geometry everywhere.

Limitations

- Shows only a sample of 500 rows for example values – rare codes can be missed (step 03 therefore lists every land-use value it could not map).

Step 02 – Prepare inputs

Why

All layers must share one coordinate system and be cut to the study area before they can be overlaid.

What the script does

- loads the AOI polygon and writes it to the GeoPackage
- reads each input **only inside the AOI** (spatial mask – much faster for Germany-wide files)
- repairs invalid geometries, reprojects to EPSG:25832, clips, recomputes areas

Results (test area)

Layer	Features	Area (ha)
AOI	1	30,358
organic soils	1,470	15,952
Feldblöcke	7,315	21,922
municipalities	34	30,358

Decisions and why

- Thünen's own AREA_HA field is dropped and recomputed: it is wrong after clipping, and GeoPackage treats area_ha and AREA_HA as the same field name.
- keep_geom_type when clipping, so stray lines/points from the cut don't end up in polygon layers.

Limitations

- Protected areas are not yet included.

Step 03 – Organic soils × agricultural land use

Why

Emissions depend on how the peat is used. The overlay answers: how much peat lies under arable land, how much under grassland, and in which municipality?

What the script does

- maps HBN codes to classes: Ackerland → cropland, Dauergrünland → grassland
- intersects Feldblöcke with organic soils, then with municipalities
- summarises hectares by soil type × land use and per municipality

Results (test area)

11,102 ha of the 15,952 ha organic soils (70 %) are farmed – **97 % of it permanent grassland** (10,824 ha), only 278 ha cropland. 104 'non-agricultural eligible areas' and one permanent crop were excluded.

Soil class	Cropland ha	Grassland ha
NH – fen	79	4,197
MF – former peat soil	112	1,773
HH – bog	3	1,693
DK_FL_NH – fen, shallow mineral cover	19	1,684
DK_MA_NH – fen, thick mineral cover	57	1,085
DK_FL_HH – bog, shallow mineral cover	8	392

Decisions and why

- Land use from the Feldblöcke (agricultural reference parcels), not from ATKIS: they are the official, current (2026) record of what is farmed.
- Very small overlay slivers are dropped.

Limitations

- A Feldblock is not an ownership parcel – one block can belong to several owners or farmers.

Step 04 – Emission estimate

Why

The core quantity of the project: how much greenhouse gas do the farmed peat soils emit, and how much would rewetting save?

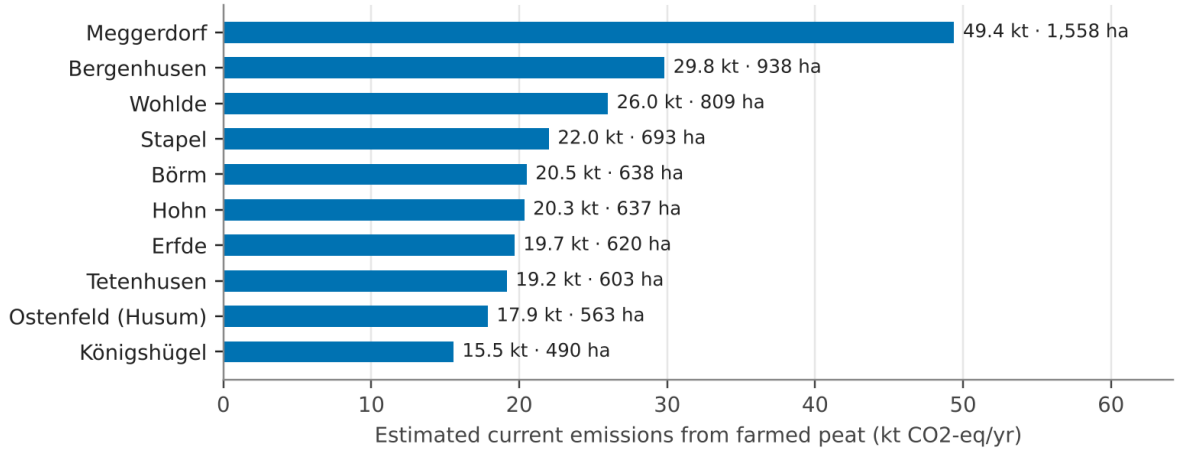
What the script does

- assigns each overlay piece the emission factor of its land-use class
- emissions = area × factor; saving = area × (factor − factor for rewetted peat)
- sums per municipality

> **Formula.** $E = \Sigma_c A_c \times EF_c \cdot \text{saving} = \Sigma_c A_c \times (EF_c - EF_{\text{rewetted}})$ with A = farmed peat area (ha), EF = emission factor, c = cropland / grassland.

Results (test area)

≈ 354,000 t CO2-eq/yr current emissions; **≈ 293,000 t** could be saved if all farmed peat were rewetted (≈ 61,000 t remain, mainly methane from wet peat). Meggerdorf alone accounts for ≈ 49,000 t.



Estimated current emissions by municipality (top 10). Because almost everything is grassland with one factor, the ranking simply follows the farmed peat area.

Class	Factor (t CO2-eq/ha/yr)	Source
cropland on organic soil	40.4	Tiemeyer et al. 2020, Table 5
grassland on organic soil	31.7	Tiemeyer et al. 2020, Table 5
rewetted organic soil	5.5	Tiemeyer et al. 2020, Table 5

Decisions and why

- **Implied national emission factors** from the German greenhouse-gas inventory method: they include CO2 (incl. dissolved organic carbon), methane from soil and ditches and nitrous oxide, converted with the IPCC AR4 warming potentials, and they already contain the undrained share of each land use – so they can be multiplied with area directly.
- The same factor is applied to all soil classes incl. former peat soils and covered peat: the paper found no emission difference between 'true peat' and lower-carbon organic soils at German farm sites (sect. 4.1.1).
- The script refuses to run without cited factors.

Limitations

- National averages: the actual water table, peat thickness and management of each field are ignored.
- Parts of the test area are in wet-grassland schemes; there the estimate is probably too high.

Step 08 – Monte Carlo: how certain is the estimate?

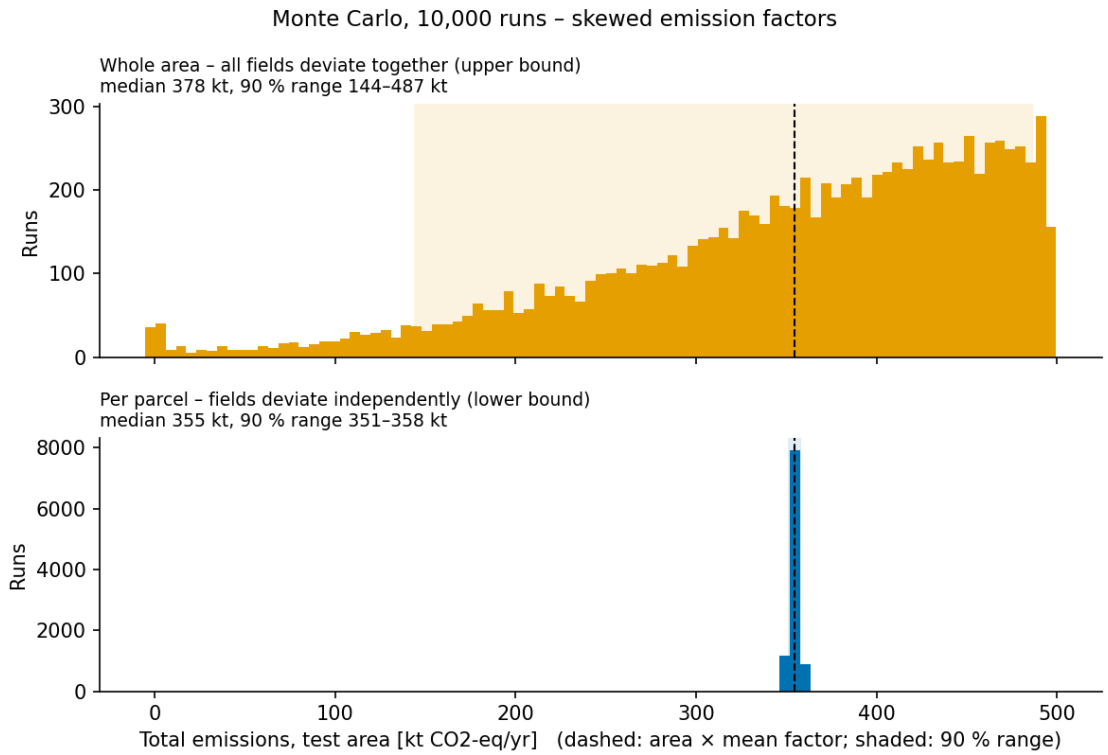
Why

A single number like 354,000 t hides its uncertainty. The question is how wide the plausible range is – and what drives it.

What the script does

- draws emission factors 10,000 times from a distribution fitted to the paper's numbers
- recomputes total emissions and savings for every draw
- runs two scenarios: **whole area** (one draw for all fields) and **per parcel** (an independent draw for each of 4,438 parcel/land-use units)

Results (test area)



Monte Carlo, 10,000 runs. Top: all fields deviate together. Bottom: fields deviate independently. Same x-axis, so the widths compare directly.

Scenario	Emissions median	90 % range	Savings median	90 % range
whole area (upper bound)	377,750	143,853 – 486,858	313,018	76,205 – 447,116
per parcel (lower bound)	354,681	350,943 – 358,406	293,210	289,232 – 297,117

Decisions and why

- **The key insight.** The paper's ranges (Table 2) are percentiles over all grid points: they describe how much *single hectares* differ, mainly because of their water level – not how uncertain the *average* over a large area is. My first version, which applied one random factor to all fields, therefore greatly overstated the uncertainty.
- **Lopsided distribution.** For drained land, most hectares emit close to a ceiling (CO2 stops rising once a field is deeply drained) with a long tail towards wetter fields. A two-piece normal distribution is fitted so that its mean equals the inventory factor exactly and its 2.5/97.5 % points match the paper within ≈ 0.7 t C/ha.
- **Physical floor.** Even a fully wet field cannot emit less than the lower limit of the paper's CO2 response curve (−0.93 t C/ha/yr); without this cap the tail produced impossible values.
- **Two bounding scenarios** instead of one guess about how strongly fields are correlated.

Limitations

- Only emission-factor variability is included – not mapping errors, the uncertainty of the response functions themselves, or the choice of warming potentials.
- Reality lies between the two scenarios: neighbouring fields share ditches and pumps.

Key point. The emission factors themselves don't make the estimate uncertain – the unknown **regional water level** does. If the whole region deviates from the national average, the range is −60 % / +35 %; if fields deviate independently, it is ±1 %. Local water-level data would narrow this down.

Step 01 – DGM1 terrain model

Why

Hydrology needs a detailed terrain model; in flat fen landscapes a few centimetres decide where water flows. The 1 m DGM1 of Schleswig-Holstein is open data.

What the script does

- works out which 1×1 km tiles touch the AOI (355)
- downloads them via the portal's official **bulk-download index** (a GeoJSON with a direct link per tile), one at a time with a 1-second pause
- converts each XYZ text tile (1,000,000 lines of x y z) straight into a compressed 1 m GeoTIFF – the 28 MB text files are never stored; ≈ 0.6 s per tile
- records each tile's survey year and writes a tile layer (present / missing / year)

Results (test area)

All **355 tiles** complete. The survey years form clear blocks: west and centre mostly **2025** (205 tiles), a northern strip **2024** (39), the east (easting ≥ 528 km) **2005/2006** (106), plus 2017 (1) and 2021 (4).

Decisions and why

- The interactive download client allows only one tile per order; the bulk index made the download automatic and reproducible – and it is the sanctioned route for mass downloads.
- HTTPS certificates are checked against the Windows certificate store (package truststore); certificate checking was never switched off.
- Safe to re-run: finished tiles are skipped; failures are listed.

Limitations

- Tiles almost 20 years apart meet at easting ≈ 528 km. Drained peat subsides by roughly 1 cm per year, so steps of centimetres to decimetres can appear at tile edges – relevant in flat terrain.

Step 05 – Hydrology with GRASS r.watershed

Why

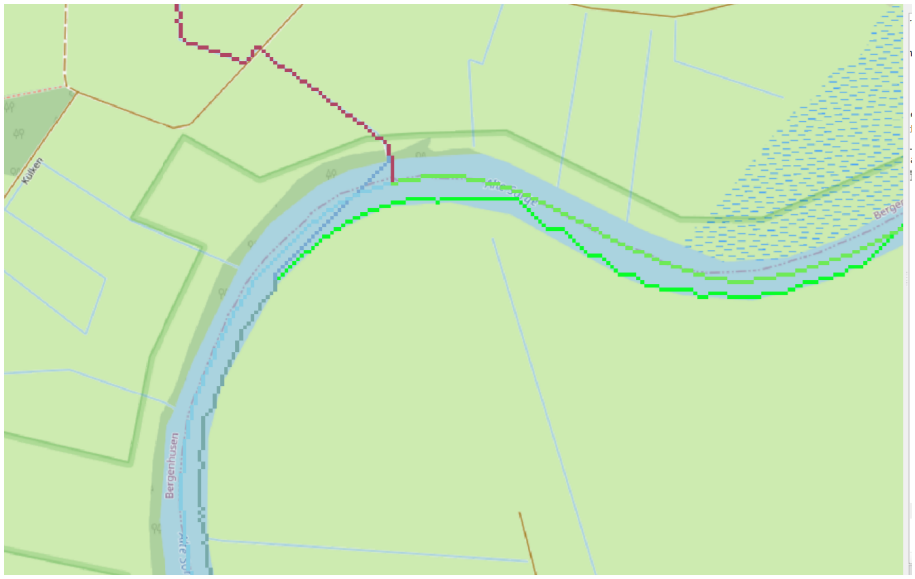
Rewetting raises the water level in a whole hydrological unit, not in a single field. To plan realistically, those units are needed: sub-catchments and the streams that connect them.

What the script does

- mosaics the 355 tiles and resamples them to a 5 m working grid
- **stream burning:** lowers the DEM by 3 m along the official water-body network (ATKIS Basis-DLM, INSPIRE download service; 1,885 km of lines in the test area, most of them field ditches)
- runs GRASS **r.watershed** through qgis_process: flow direction (D8), flow accumulation, streams, sub-catchments of at least 50 ha (20,000 cells)
- vectorises the sub-catchments, computes their share of organic soil and flags catchments touching the AOI/DEM edge as incomplete

Results (test area)

	Run 1 (mean)	Run 2 (min)	Run 3 (min + burning, used)
sub-catchments	393	367	350
incomplete (touch the edge)	80	80	84
complete and ≥ 50 % organic soil	207	196	178 (14,002 ha; 11,651 ha peat)



Alte Sorge near Bergenhusen. Dark blue: modelled stream without burning, partly beside the river. Other colours: stream sections with burning – on the river's centre line, with a tributary (red) joining at a mapped ditch. Background © OpenStreetMap contributors.

Visual check: the catchment boundaries run largely along dykes, dams and road embankments – realistic for a polder landscape, where these are the true water divides.

Decisions and why

- **r.watershed** routes water through depressions with a least-cost search, so no 'fill sinks' step is needed. Filling would create large artificial flats in fen terrain.
- **Minimum instead of mean** when resampling 1 m → 5 m. Ditches are only 1–3 m wide; averaging smoothed them away and streams wandered across fields in stair-steps. Taking the lowest 1 m cell keeps ditch bottoms connected – the streams now follow the ditch pattern.
- Outputs are named after the method (stream_min.tif …), so both runs can be compared in QGIS.
- **Stream burning** (added later): many ditches are narrower than a 5 m cell or pass through culverts, so even the minimum DEM lets streams drift beside the real watercourses. Cutting the mapped network 3 m into the DEM makes the flow follow it. Official water bodies within 10 m of a modelled stream rise from 7 % to 12 % – low in absolute terms because GRASS only draws a stream once 50 ha drain through it, while most of the network is small field ditches.

Limitations

- **Pumping stations.** The polders are drained by ditches and pumps that lift water into the embanked Alte Sorge. A terrain model cannot see pumps, culverts or pipe drains, so the main river is not recognised as the main drain.
- The real drainage units are the pumping-station catchments of the water and soil associations (Wasser- und Bodenverbände); the DEM catchments approximate them.
- Wide rivers are burned only along their centre line; inside the 30–40 m wide Alte Sorge a second, parallel stream remains along the deepest part of the bed. All water still ends in the river, so only tiny slivers between the two lines are affected.

Step 07 – Optimisation: parcels vs. catchments

Why

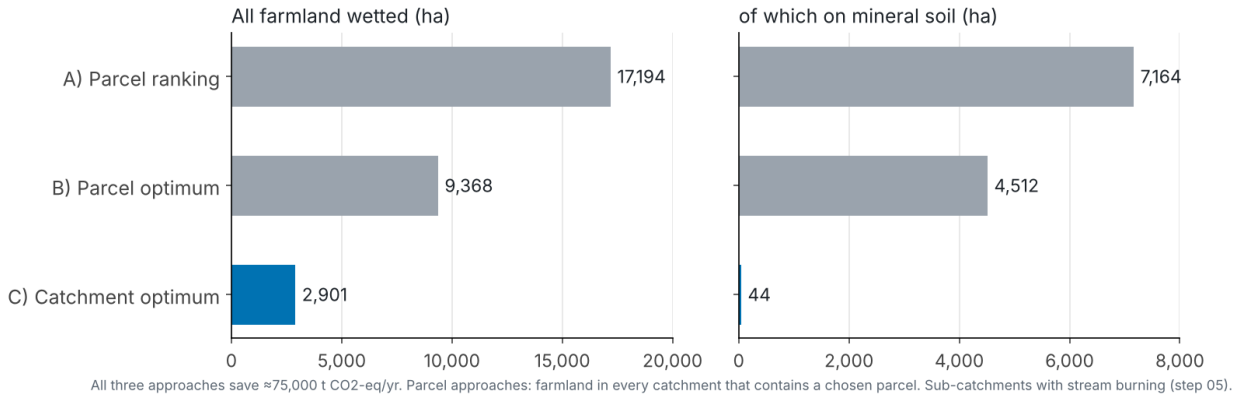
A ranking ('best fields first') is the intuitive way to choose areas. The question is whether an optimisation does better – and what changes when hydrology is taken into account.

What the script does

- **A) Parcel ranking:** Feldblöcke sorted by saving per ha, taken until the target is reached
- **B) Parcel optimum:** binary integer programme over 3,411 parcels – least area that reaches the target
- **C) Catchment optimum:** the same over 248 complete sub-catchments – a catchment is chosen whole; the objective is to wet as little farmland on **mineral** soil as possible
- for A and B it also counts what would really get wet: all farmland in every catchment that contains a chosen parcel

> **Integer programme.** Choose $x_i \in \{0, 1\}$ for every unit i (parcel or catchment): minimise $\Sigma\ \text{cost}_i \cdot x_i$ subject to $\Sigma\ \text{saving}_i \cdot x_i \geq \text{target}$. Cost = area (B) or mineral-soil farmland in the catchment (C).

Results (test area)



All three approaches save ≈75,000 t CO2-eq/yr. Parcel approaches: farmland in every catchment that contains a chosen parcel. Sub-catchments with stream burning (step 05).

Approach	Units	Peat rewetted ha	Saving t/yr	Catchments	Farmland wetted ha	on mineral soil ha
A) ranking	914 parcels	2,791	75,037	220	17,194*	7,164*
B) parcel optimum	808 parcels	2,789	75,001	121	9,368*	4,512*
C) catchment optimum	78 catchments	2,857	75,001	78	2,901	44

* if the water level is raised in every catchment containing a selected parcel – which is what rewetting physically does.

Decisions and why

- Target 75,000 t CO2-eq/yr ≈ a quarter of the potential: large enough that the solver has to choose.
- Solver: SciPy milp (HiGHS) – no external program, all three models solved to proven optimality in seconds.
- Without hydrology, A and B are almost identical (2,791 vs 2,789 ha): with only two emission factors nearly every hectare saves the same, so optimisation cannot beat a ranking – an important result in itself.
- Each parcel is assigned to the catchment containing its interior point, so parcels touching a boundary are not counted twice (this corrected A and B by ≈ 10–15 %).
- Objective switchable in config.py: non_peat_farmland (default), affected_farmland, count.

Limitations

- Uses the DEM catchments (see step 05). With pumping-station catchments the result could change.
- No costs, ownership, protected areas or farmers' willingness yet.
- Savings are estimates with the uncertainty from step 08.

Key point. Planned field by field, rewetting looks efficient but would wet 4,500–7,200 ha of farmland on mineral soil that emits nothing. Planned by sub-catchment, the same 75,000 t are reached with 44 ha – about 100 times less collateral damage. Hydrology turns the optimisation from a formality into the core of the analysis.

Step 06 – Wet land 1878–80 vs. organic soils today

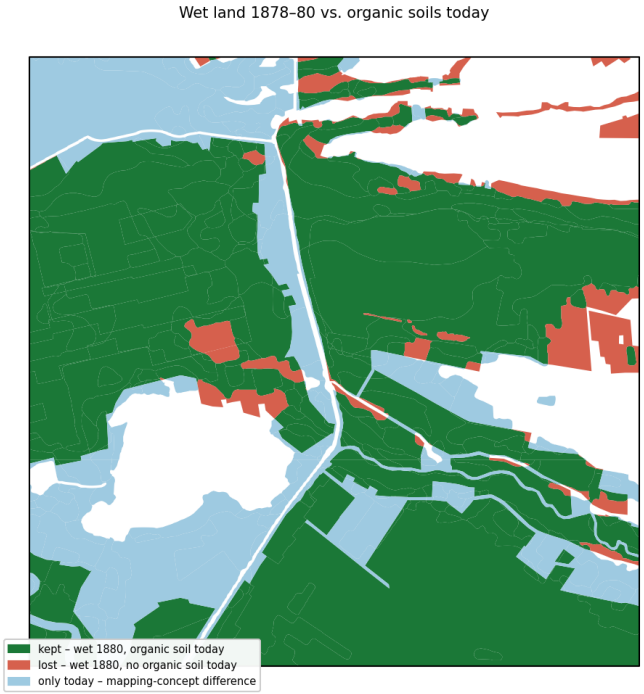
Why

Today's soil map shows where peat is now. The first Prussian survey of 1878–80 shows where the land was wet 150 years ago. Comparing the two shows how stable the peat landscape is, where peat has been lost, and how far drainage had already progressed by 1880.

What the script does

- **manual part (QGIS):** I digitised the wet signatures of the 1878–80 sheets (WMS Chronologen) by hand at 1:2,500–1:5,000 in a 6 × 6 km block around Meggerdorf (36 km²), recording the **legend class** the map shows rather than an interpretation; the checked area is stored separately as `digitised_extent`
- checks every polygon's class and turns the free-text evidence (e.g. 'torfstich, tufts, long dashes') into codes (bruch, torfstich, name)
- clips to the checked area and closes gaps of up to 30 m between neighbouring polygons (roads, ditches)
- overlays with today's organic soils: **kept** (wet then, organic now), **lost** (wet then, no organic soil now), **only today** (organic now, no wet signature then)
- reports how much of each difference lies within 25 m of a boundary (possible position error)

Results (test area)



Green: wet in 1878–80 and organic soil today. Red: wet then, no organic soil today. Light blue: organic soil today without a wet signature in 1880. Black frame: the 36 km² block that was checked.

Category	ha	Meaning
kept	2,007	92 % of the 1880 wet land
lost	175	≈ ⅓ of it within 25 m of a boundary – real loss ≈ 120–175 ha
only today	721	mostly fen (NH 423 ha) shown as pasture, dry meadow or arable in 1880

1880 class	Area ha	Kept %	Main soil type today (kept area)
Moor	1,086	95	Hochmoor 787 ha, Moorfolgeboden 119 ha
nasse Wiese	1,067	91	Niedermoor 465 ha, **Moorfolgeboden 336 ha**
Heide	29	6	– (mostly no organic soil today)

Decisions and why

- **Legend from the same survey series.** A 1933 legend first suggested one meadow class; the official *Zeichen-Erklärung für die Messtischblätter* (1898) separates nasse Wiese, trockene Wiese, Hutung/Viehweide, nasser Boden, Heide and Sumpf/Bruch/Moor. It explained why two different dash patterns appeared on the map, and I rebuilt the classes on it.
- **Record what the map shows, interpret later.** I digitised the classes Moor (peat certain), nasser Boden and nasse Wiese (likely) and Heide in the lowland (possible). I left out pasture, dry meadow, sand, arable land and villages.
- **Recurring Torfstich makes Moor**; a single peat cutting is only noted, so one symbol cannot turn a whole meadow into moor.
- **A separate extent layer**, so unchecked land is not mistaken for 'dry in 1880'.
- **Gap closing tested:** 15 m vs. 30 m changes every category by ≤ 1 %; I used 30 m.

Limitations

- Map signatures (land use and wetness) are compared with a soil map – different concepts. 'Only today' is therefore no gain of peat but fen that was already drained in 1880.
- Hand digitising, the positional accuracy of the 1880 survey and a key ~20 years younger than the sheets add uncertainty.
- One 36 km² block, which I chose for its mix of bog, fen and geest; not representative of the whole state.

Key point. Peat in this lowland has been remarkably stable in extent: 92 % of the land that was wet in 1878–80 is still organic soil. But it has thinned: about a third of the former wet meadows are now **Moorfolgeboden**, soils whose peat has largely gone – the long-term result of the drainage that steps 04 and 07 are about.

Steps 06x–06c – Reading the 1880 map automatically (YOLO)

Why

Hand digitising the 36 km² block took me several hours; the whole state is more than 400 times larger. I wanted to know whether the same classes can be derived automatically – with a small object-detection model for the map symbols and the same rules I used by hand – trained and run entirely on my own computer.

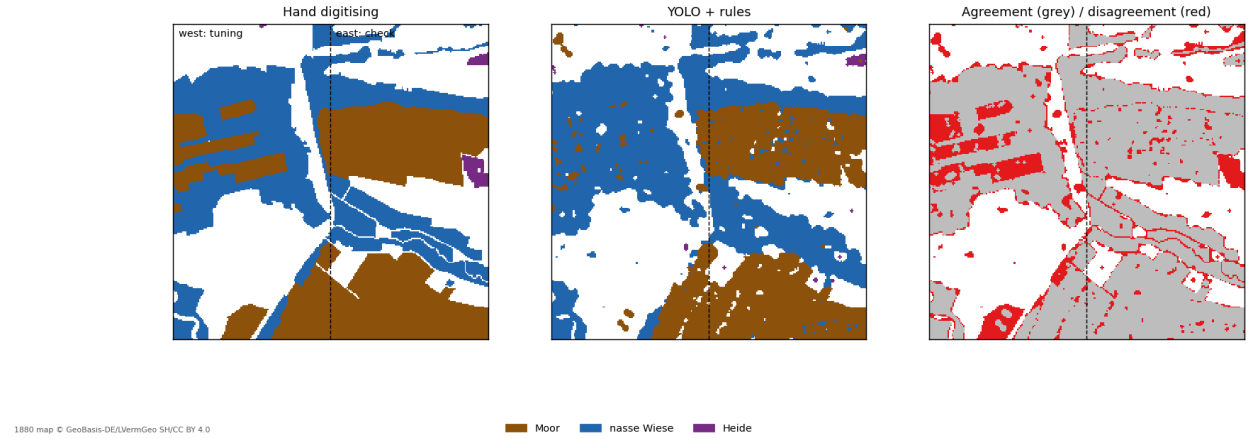
What the script does

- **06x:** the 1 m GeoTIFF of the block (exported from the Chronologen WCS) is cut into 361 tiles of 320 m, enlarged to 640 px, so a tuft becomes about 25 px instead of 12
- **labelling (QGIS):** I marked every tuft (point) and every peat cutting (Torfstich, rectangle) in 32 tiles – 400 tufts, 25 chains – including 11 tiles without symbols (dense dashes, lettering, a village)
- **06y:** labels → YOLO format (tuft points → 16 m boxes); split 24 / 4 / 4 tiles, with tiles that share an edge kept in the same set and every set containing moor, meadow and empty tiles
- **training:** Ultralytics YOLO26n on the CPU (about 15 minutes), stopped early at epoch 124
- **06z:** point-based check – a symbol counts as found if a detection lies within 8 m
- **06b:** detection on all 361 tiles, duplicates merged, converted to map coordinates
- **06c:** dash filter + tufts + Torfstich → classes on a 25 m grid; thresholds tuned on the west half of the block, result checked on the east half

Results (test area)

Symbol detection (4 test tiles, conf ≥ 0.20)	Recall	Precision*
tuft (53 labelled)	0.75	0.59
Torfstich (4 labelled)	3 of 4	0.50

* before duplicates are merged; two boxes on one tuft count as one hit and one false hit.



Left: my hand digitising. Middle: YOLO detections + rules. Right: agreement (grey) and disagreement (red). Dashed line: west half used for tuning, east half for checking.

Area	Agreement	Cohen's κ	IoU Moor	IoU nasse Wiese
west (tuning)	84 %	0.74	–	–
east (not used for tuning)	**90 %**	**0.86**	0.91	0.76

Decisions and why

- **Tiles of 320 m enlarged ×2.** YOLO looks at the image in steps of 8 px; a 12 px tuft is barely more than one step. Enlarging adds no detail but gives the network enough pixels.
- **Less scale augmentation (scale = 0.2).** The default shrinks training images by up to 50 %, which turns tufts into specks that never occur on the real map.
- **A point-based check instead of mAP alone.** mAP50 (0.52 for tufts) counts a box 5 m off as a miss. For counting tufts per 75 m window that is irrelevant; the point check showed the model finds 86 % of tufts in the validation tiles – with low confidence, so the threshold was lowered to 0.20.
- **Dashes without machine learning.** Flat ink marks (≤ 3 m high, 5–40 m long) are the dashes of Bruch and nasse Wiese; dotted pasture rows, lettering, buildings and field lines fall outside these limits. Dash density alone separates wet from not-wet land with an AUC of 0.97.
- **The same rules as by hand**, including 'heath in a moor': heath tufts near recurring Torfstich, or joined to a larger moor, become Moor. I added this rule after a first run classified the drained Königsmoor as heath (κ 0.76 → 0.85); it comes from my digitising rules, not from the check data.
- **Honest evaluation.** Thresholds are tuned on the west half only; the east half is the check. The YOLO test tiles were evaluated once, at the end.

Limitations

- The model was trained on tiles from the same block it is evaluated on (different tiles, same sheet and engraver). Other sheets need spot checks before it is applied there.
- Moor names are not detected; the small Heide class (29 ha) is not reproduced.
- Nasse Wiese is drawn slightly too wide (78 ha in the east half where I drew nothing), mostly into pasture with fairly dense dash rows.
- Only 23 Torfstich chains for training – that class is the weakest part of the model.

> **Key point.** A small model trained on 32 hand-labelled tiles, combined with simple image analysis for the dashes and my own digitising rules, reads the 1880 map almost as I did by hand: 90 % agreement on land it was not tuned on.

Applying it to the whole test area (06x–06c aoi, 06, 06v)

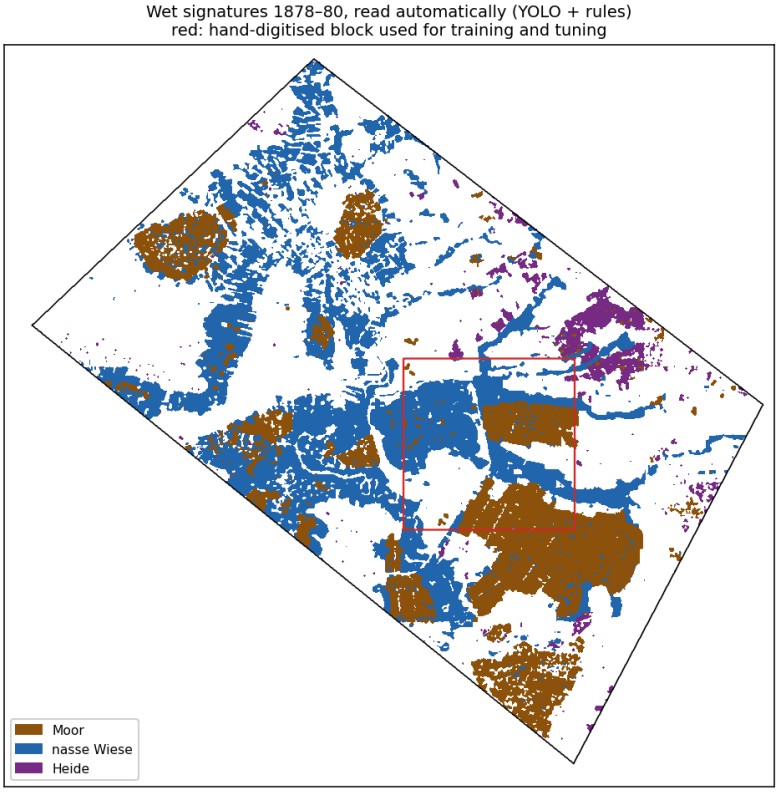
Why

The point of automating the map reading is scale. I applied the model and the thresholds tuned on the block, without re-tuning, to the whole test area (304 km², about eight times the block) – and then checked the result blindly, because outside the block there is no hand-digitised reference.

What the script does

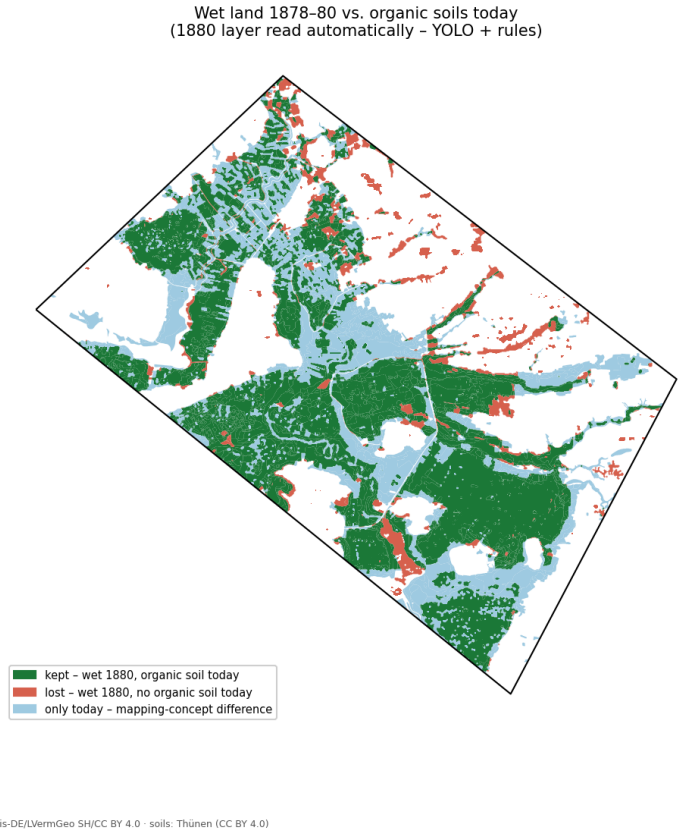
- exported the 1880 map for the whole test area from the WCS (27,000 × 26,000 px at 1 m) and cut it into 3,119 tiles inside the AOI
- detection on all tiles in about 20 minutes on a laptop CPU: 11,943 tufts, 771 Torfstich (first model; the final map takes the Torfstich of the second model – 1,129 – and measures dash density per field, see the next two sections)
- 12 random spot-check tiles outside the block with the detections drawn, which I inspected
- rules applied with the block thresholds; step 06 repeated for the whole area
- **06v:** 100 random points outside the block, 25 per mapped class; I classified each from the 1880 map without seeing the prediction; area-weighted accuracy after Olofsson et al. (2014)

Results (test area)



1880 classes for the whole test area, read automatically. Red frame: the hand-digitised block used for training and tuning.

Class (outside the block), final map	Mapped ha	User's acc.	Producer's acc.	Estimated ha ± 95 %
Moor	3,690	0.89	0.93	3,714 ± 726
nasse Wiese	5,881	0.86	0.86	4,754 ± 1,668
Heide	831	0.89	0.78	910 ± 393
none	16,356	0.96	0.96	17,381 ± 1,605
Overall accuracy		**93 % ± 4 %**		



Wet land 1878–80 (automated) vs. organic soils today, whole test area.

	Block (hand, 36 km²)	Whole test area (automated)
wet land 1880	2,182 ha	11,872 ha
still organic soil today	92 %	88 % (10,441 ha)
lost	175 ha	1,431 ha (upper bound)
1880 Moor → today's raised bog (HH)	73 %	81 % of kept
1880 nasse Wiese → Moorfolgeboden	31 %	20 % of kept
organic today, not wet in 1880	721 ha	5,511 ha

Decisions and why

- **No re-tuning outside the block.** The thresholds come from the block; the whole-area result is therefore a real test of transfer, and the 100 points are an independent check.
- **Two rule fixes after the first whole-area run.** A dry heath near Friedrichsneuland came out as Moor: tuft base lines were counted as dashes, and the heath-in-a-moor rule spread over the whole heath from a few moor-like cells. Base lines within 10 m of a tuft are now ignored, and heath only joins a moor at least as large as itself. On the block this changes nothing (κ 0.85 → 0.86). I made these fixes before drawing the 100 check points.
- **Automated Heide left out of the 1880 wet land**: heath away from any moor is mostly geest heath, not evidence of peat (in the first run: lost 2,017 → 1,365 ha).
- **The check points were never used to tune a threshold.** They were used afterwards to choose between variants of the second training round and the dash method (next sections), which makes the final 93 % slightly optimistic.

Limitations

- Nasse Wiese remains the least certain class (user's accuracy 0.86) – the 'lost' area is therefore an upper bound.
- Larger tufts drawn in a different style are still often missed; peat cuttings at steep angles were improved in the second round.
- Land around peat cuttings becomes ~125 m squares, not whole fields as I would draw by hand.
- 25 points per class give wide confidence intervals, especially for nasse Wiese.

Key point. Applied without re-tuning to an area eight times larger, the method reaches 93 % ± 4 % accuracy in a blind check. The main historical result holds at this scale: most of today's peat (88 % of the 1880 wet land) was already wet land in 1878–80, 1880 Moor is today's raised bog, and part of the former wet meadows has lost its peat since.

Second training round – what helped and what didn't

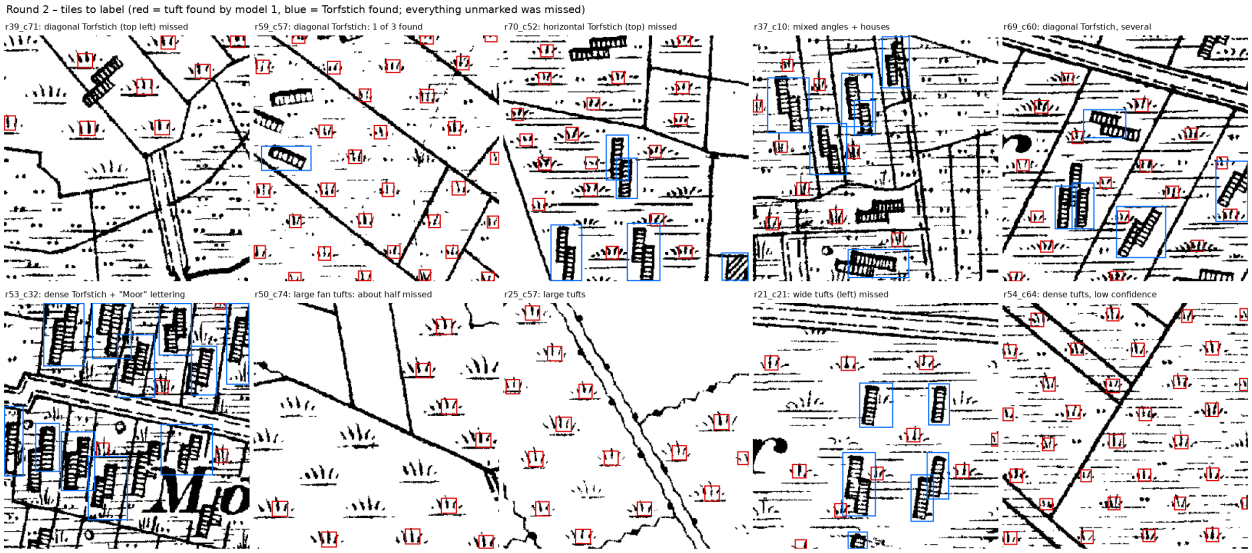
Why

The spot checks and the blind check showed three weak points: peat cuttings drawn diagonally or horizontally, large fan-shaped tufts, and nasse Wiese spreading into pasture rows. I tested whether more labels would fix them.

What the script does

- chose 10 tiles outside the block that show the first two weak points – none of them contains or borders one of the 100 check points, so the blind check stays independent
- labelled every symbol in them: 181 tufts and 36 peat cuttings (in total now 583 and 65)
- **06y:** the new tiles go into training only; validation and test tiles stay exactly as in round 1
- retrained YOLO26n with moderate rotation (±30°) and no vertical flip – tufts are always drawn upright; 28 minutes on the CPU
- compared the maps with the same 100 points and my same readings (06v compare)

Results (test area)



The 10 extra tiles with the detections of the first model (red: tufts, blue: peat cuttings). Everything without a box was missed.

Blind check, 100 points	Round 1	Round 2	Round 1 tufts + round 2 peat cuttings
Overall accuracy	90 % ± 6 %	90 % ± 6 %	**91 % ± 6 %**
Moor, user's / producer's acc.	0.92 / 0.86	0.84 / 0.89	0.90 / 0.93
nasse Wiese	0.72 / 0.86	0.77 / 0.81	0.78 / 0.86
Heide	0.84 / 0.69	0.92 / 0.78	0.89 / 0.81
Block, east half (κ)	0.86	0.86	0.86

Decisions and why

- **The new model finds peat cuttings much better** – all 6 in the validation and test tiles, 46 % more on the whole area – but its tuft confidences cluster between 0.15 and 0.25. At 0.20 it finds 17 % of the test tufts, at 0.15 it finds 77 % but also 'tufts' in dashed meadows; tufts + dashes become false Moor. Training longer did not change this.
- **My first explanation was wrong.** I suspected that the extra peat cuttings spread Moor through the rule 'recurring Torfstich → Moor'. Tuning that rule on the block (now ≥ 3 cuttings per 275 m instead of 2) changed less than 1 % of the Moor and not a single check point. Looking at the 8 points that changed showed the real cause: the tufts.
- **Each symbol from the model that is reliable for it.** The final map uses the tufts of round 1 and the peat cuttings of round 2. This choice rests on the validation and test tiles, not only on the check points.
- Comparing a new map with a sample drawn from an older one needs the estimator for strata that differ from the map classes (Stehman 2014).

Limitations

- The gain is within the confidence interval, and the combination is the third variant checked against the same 100 points – 'slightly better, not significantly better'.
- The pasture rows are a weakness of the dash rule, not of the model; more labels cannot fix them.
- Two models are needed to produce one map.

Key point. More training data improved the detection of the target symbol, but the downstream rule turned the second model's uncertain tufts into false Moor. Evaluating the whole chain, not just the model's own scores, showed where the bottleneck really was.

Dash density per field

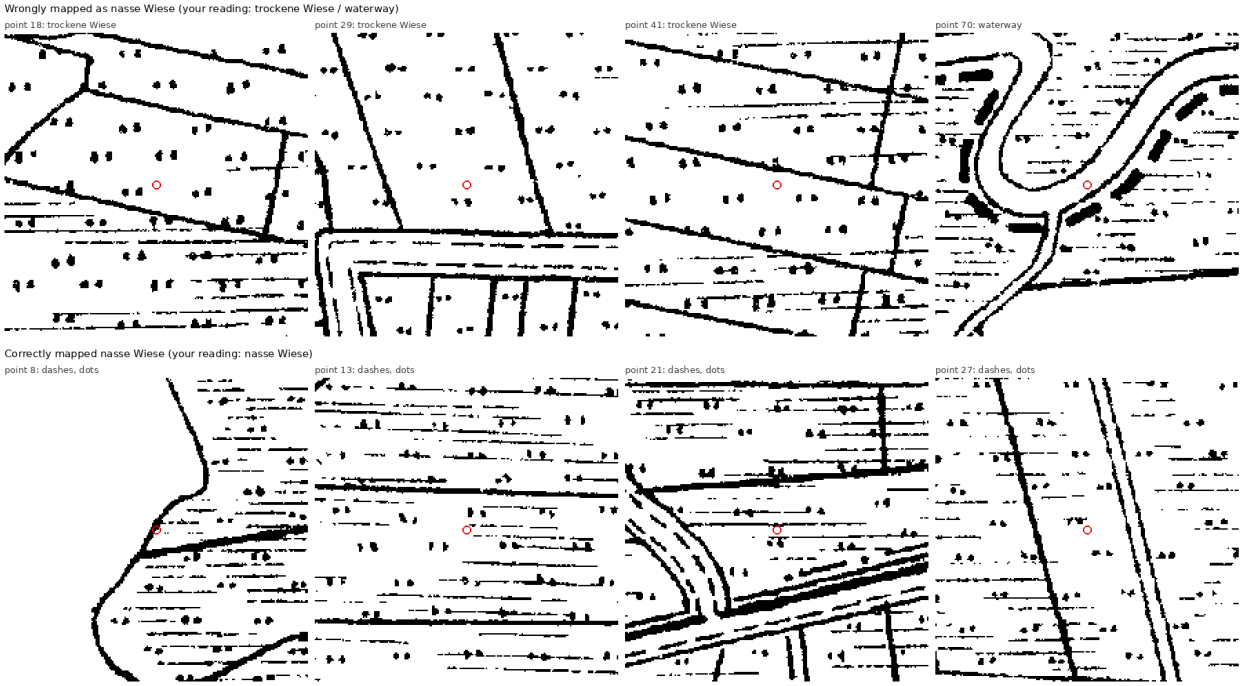
Why

After the second round, most remaining nasse Wiese errors sat in dry meadow (trockene Wiese: rows of dot pairs, no dashes). I cut out the map at those check points to see why.

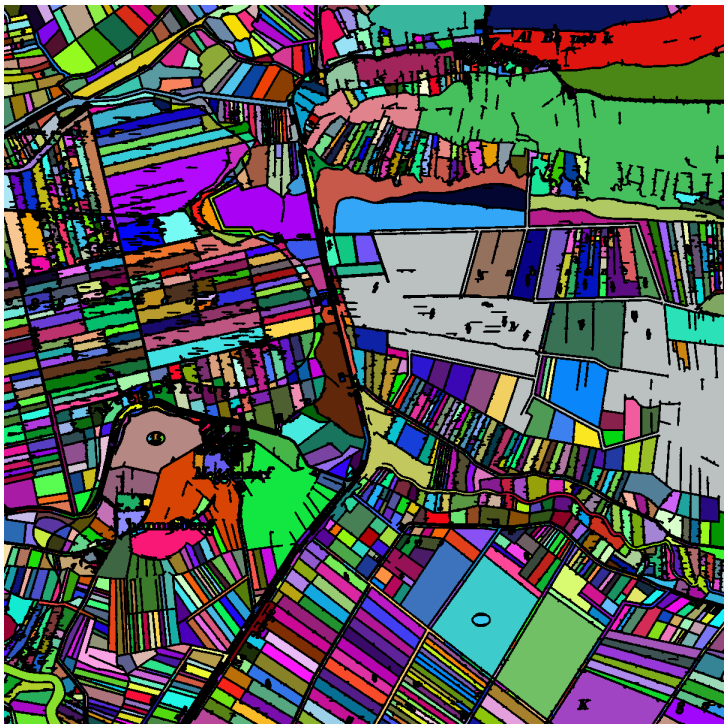
What the script does

- compared map sections at the wrongly and the correctly mapped check points (figure)
- found that the dot pairs are ignored correctly – but the 125 m moving window reaches across the field line into a neighbouring wet meadow and 'pulls' its dashes into the dry field
- **new:** ink longer than 80 m (field lines, ditches, roads) splits the map into fields on a 5 m grid; the dash density is computed inside each field. Slivers under 0.2 ha and open areas over 40 ha keep the window value
- 06c tries both methods on the west half of the block

Results (test area)



Top: check points wrongly mapped as nasse Wiese (my reading: dry meadow, waterway). Bottom: correctly mapped nasse Wiese. Each section 220 × 220 m.



The fields found in the hand-digitised block from the map's own field lines (one colour per field).

Dash density	κ west (tuning)	κ east (check)	Blind check (points right)	Area-weighted
moving window	0.740	0.856	88 of 100	91 % ± 6 %
per field	0.736	**0.866**	87 of 100	**93 % ± 4 %**

Decisions and why

- **A decision rule set before the blind check.** The methods were equal on the west half (0.004 κ apart), so I decided: within 0.01 κ the field method wins, because it follows my digitising rule 'boundaries follow the field line' – and only then ran the check.
- Fields come from the 1880 map itself, not from today's parcels: field boundaries have changed since.

Limitations

- The field method fixes two of the three dry-meadow errors but misses three wet meadows with sparse dashes. In plain counts it is a draw; the higher area-weighted figure rests on one point in the large 'none' stratum.
- Field lines with gaps wider than about 10 m let neighbouring fields merge.

Key point. The errors were not in the symbol filter but in the window around it. Measuring per field – the unit the surveyors drew – keeps the accuracy and makes the boundaries follow the fields.

Step 07b – The 1880 map per sub-catchment

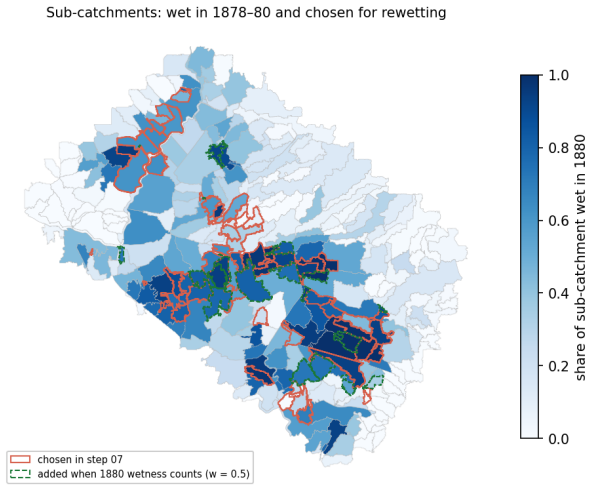
Why

Step 07 chooses sub-catchments from today's soils and land use only. The 1880 map adds a second perspective: were the chosen units wet land before large-scale drainage – where rewetting restores an earlier state and is probably easier hydrologically?

What the script does

- intersects the final 1880 layer and today's soils with the 350 sub-catchments: wet in 1880 (Moor + nasse Wiese), Moor in 1880, Moorfolgeboden today, farmed peat that was wet in 1880
- compares the 78 chosen sub-catchments with the 170 other candidates
- re-runs the catchment model of step 07 with an extra cost for farmed peat that was **not** wet in 1880 (weights 0.25, 0.5, 1 – a choice, not a measured value)

Results (test area)



1880 map © GeoBasis-DE/LVermGeo SH/CC BY 4.0 · DGM1 © GeoBasis-DE/LVermGeo SH/CC BY 4.0 · soils: Thünen (CC BY 4.0)

Sub-catchments shaded by their share of wet land in 1878–80. Red outline: chosen in step 07. Green dashed: added when 1880 wetness counts (weight 0.5).

Group	Catchments	Wet in 1880	of it Moor	Farmed peat wet in 1880	Moorfolgeboden
chosen in step 07	78	**68 %**	30 %	66 %	17 %
other candidates	170	40 %	15 %	60 %	13 %
all complete	266	44 %	18 %	62 %	14 %

Weight	Catchments	Same as step 07	Mineral-soil farmland ha	Farmed peat wet in 1880
0 (step 07)	78	–	44	66 %
0.25	68	59	79	80 %
0.5	73	54	133	85 %
1	73	50	169	87 %

Decisions and why

- Shares are area-weighted over each group, so large catchments count more.
- The weight is deliberately varied rather than fixed: the table shows the trade-off instead of hiding it in one number.

Limitations

- 'Wet in 1880' describes map signatures, not water levels, and comes from the automated layer (93 % ± 4 %).
- Moorfolgeboden shares refer to today's organic soil; they say where peat has been lost, not why.

Key point. Although step 07 knew nothing about 1880, it chose sub-catchments that were mostly wet land then (68 % vs 40 %) – and that have lost more peat since (17 % Moorfolgeboden vs 13 %). Preferring historically wet land costs little: about 90 ha more mineral-soil farmland for a selection in which 85 % of the rewetted farmed peat was wet in 1880.

Step 09 – Atlas (PyQGIS)

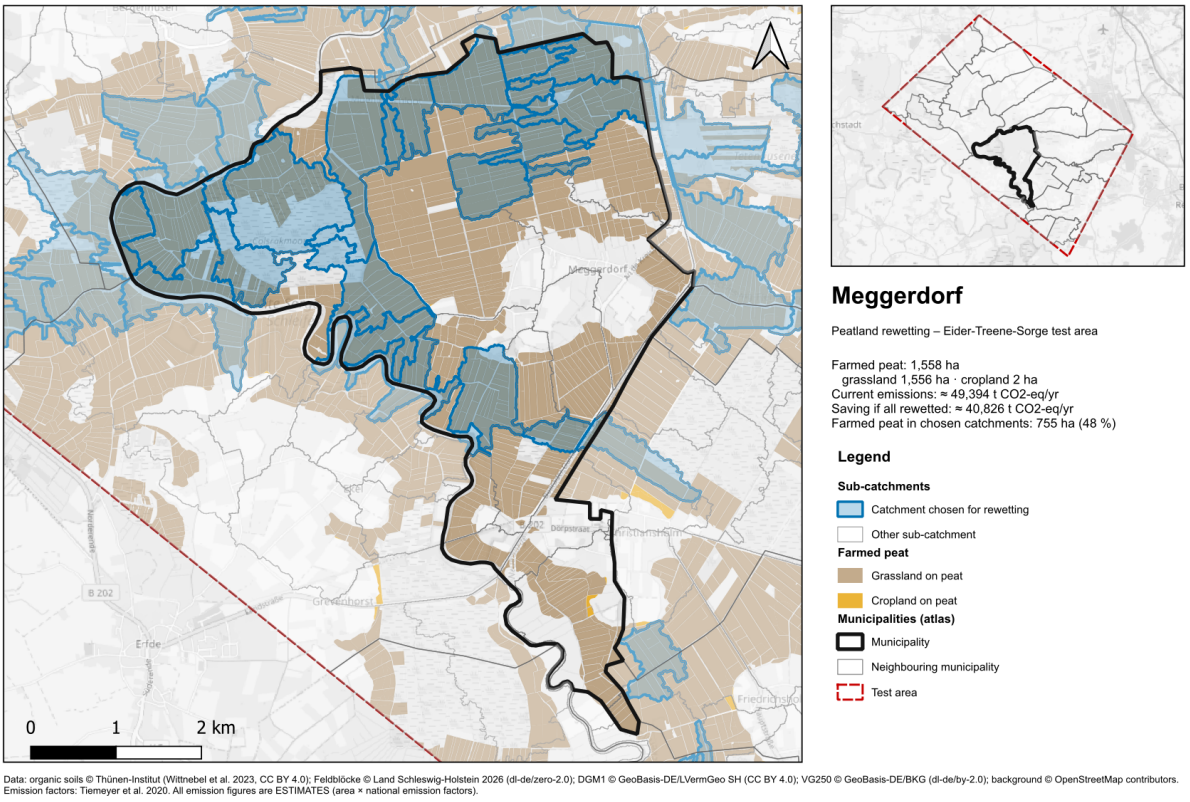
Why

Results have to be communicated per municipality – the level at which planning and talks with landowners happen.

What the script does

- builds a coverage layer: the 24 municipalities with at least 50 ha farmed peat, with key figures
- loads and styles all map layers in a separate group (other layers in the project stay untouched)
- creates the print layout 'Atlas_Gemeinden' (A4 landscape): main map following each municipality, overview map, title, key figures, legend, scale bar, north arrow, sources
- exports one PDF with all pages plus one PNG per municipality, biggest emitters first

Results (test area)



Atlas page for Meggerdorf. Blue: sub-catchments chosen by the catchment optimum; brown: grassland on peat; black: the municipality.

Decisions and why

- Everything scripted, so the maps can be re-made after any analysis change in one run.
- Legend fonts set explicitly (QGIS defaults are far too large for an 84 mm column); English number format; sources in a strip along the page bottom.
- zoomToExtent instead of setExtent – the latter silently resizes the map frame.

Limitations

- The PDF is still ≈ 77 MB (many detailed polygons on 24 pages); for GitHub or e-mail, a reduced version is needed.
- Re-running the script overwrites manual changes in the layout.

5 Main findings

- **Most of the peat is farmed, almost all as grassland.** 70 % of the organic soils in the test area are in Feldblöcke, 97 % of that permanent grassland. The cropland/grassland split therefore explains little; what differs between fields is mainly their water level.
- **The order of magnitude is large.** ≈ 354,000 t CO2-eq/yr from ≈ 11,100 ha – about 32 t per hectare and year, consistent with a grassland-dominated area under the national method.
- **The uncertainty is a data gap, not a statistical problem.** The estimate is stable (±1 %) if fields deviate independently, but could be −60 % / +35 % if the whole region is wetter or drier than the German average. Regional water-level data are the key to a better estimate.
- **Without hydrology, optimisation adds nothing.** With uniform factors, ranking and optimisation choose the same area; any apparent 'priority list' of fields is false precision.
- **With hydrology, the picture changes completely.** Planning by sub-catchment reaches the same target while wetting ≈ 100 times less farmland on mineral soil (44 ha vs 4,512 ha) – concentrated in 78 units that are almost pure peat. Burning the ditch network into the terrain model changes the units but not this result.
- **The chosen units were wet land in 1880.** 68 % of their area was wet on the 1878–80 map (other candidates: 40 %), and they have lost more peat since. Preferring historically wet land costs about 90 ha of mineral-soil farmland.
- **The peat has been there for at least 150 years – but it is thinning.** 92 % of the land shown as wet on the 1878–80 map is still organic soil; 1880 'Moor' corresponds to today's raised bog. About a third of the 1880 wet meadows are now Moorfolgeboden, and 721 ha of today's fen were already drained pasture or dry meadow in 1880.
- **The historical map can be read automatically.** A small YOLO model plus rule-based dash detection reproduces my hand digitising on 90 % of the area it was not tuned on ($\kappa = 0.86$) and reaches 93 % ± 4 % accuracy in a blind check across the whole test area. Across 304 km², 88 % of the 1880 wet land is still organic soil today.
- **Evaluate the whole chain.** A second model found peat cuttings much better but made the map no better, because its uncertain tufts became false Moor further down the chain. Combining the reliable parts of both models gave the best map.
- **Data quality matters in flat terrain.** Terrain-model resampling (minimum vs mean) and survey dates 20 years apart visibly affect streams and catchments.

6 Limitations of the whole approach

Limitation	Effect	How it could be addressed
National average emission factors	local water level, peat thickness, management ignored	water-level map (Thünen), field data, response functions
DEM-based catchments in pumped polders	pumps and pipe drains invisible; ditches burned in along centre lines only	pumping-station catchments of the water boards
Hand-drawn test area	80 sub-catchments cut at the edge	use a real catchment as AOI
Mixed DGM1 survey years	possible steps at tile edges	map and discuss; check edges
Feldblock ≠ ownership parcel	no statement about owners	ALKIS (not open)
No costs, protected areas, willingness	optimum is purely physical	add constraints / costs
Monte Carlo covers factors only	mapping errors not included	add area uncertainty
Historical comparison: map signatures vs. soil map	'only today' is not a peat gain	keep the categories separate; field data on peat depth

Limitation	Effect	How it could be addressed
Hand digitising of one 36 km² block	position error, subjectivity	edge tolerance reported; YOLO test for reproducibility
YOLO trained mostly in one block	nasse Wiese least certain (user's acc. 0.86); second model's tuft confidences unstable; variants chosen with the same check points	pilot regions with new check points before using it state-wide

7 Problems encountered and how they were solved

Problem	Cause	Solution
Inputs reported as MISSING	data sat one or two folders deeper after unzipping	paths adjusted in config.py
ValueError when counting features	empty column list not allowed by pyogrio	count from file header (read_info)
'Error adding field area_ha'	GeoPackage field names are case-insensitive (AREA_HA exists)	drop old field before recomputing
Miniforge installer failed	Smart App Control (Device Guard) blocks unsigned programs	use QGIS's bundled Python
PuLP TypeError (cat=…)	PuLP 4.0 changed its API; CBC solver would be blocked anyway	SciPy milp with HiGHS
Uncertainty looked 'massive'	per-hectare ranges applied as area uncertainty	two-piece normal + two correlation scenarios
Impossible negative emissions	unbounded lower tail of the distribution	floor at CO2-Cmin = −0.93 t C/ha/yr
Only one DGM1 tile per order	deliberate limit of the download client	official bulk-download GeoJSON index
CERTIFICATE_VERIFY_FAILED	QGIS's Python doesn't use the Windows certificate store	truststore package (checking stays on)
r.watershed 'not found'	qgis_process loads plugins separately; LTR command name	qgis_process-qgis-ltr plugins enable grassprovider
Streams across fields	mean resampling erased 1–3 m ditches	minimum resampling
Parcels counted in two catchments	touching boundaries counted as intersecting	assign by interior point
Atlas inset too tall, legend overlapping	setExtent resizes the frame; default legend fonts	zoomToExtent; compact legend
Map symbols misread (heath vs. moor, one meadow class)	1933 legend; 1882 key not accessible	official 1898 key of the same survey series
'Field evidence not found' in QGIS	field had been created as 'evidence ' (trailing space)	script strips field names
New polygons cut to slivers	invisible polygons without class + 'avoid overlap'	catch-all symbol category; reassign or delete
Road strips between 1880 polygons	roads and ditches left out while digitising	gap closing (30 m), sensitivity tested
Tufts too small for YOLO	12 px at 1 m; finest YOLO grid step is 8 px	320 m tiles enlarged to 640 px; less scale augmentation
Recall looked low (mAP50 0.52)	IoU criterion too strict for 16 m boxes; low confidences	point-based check; threshold 0.20; duplicates merged
Tile flags not saved	Field Calculator edit left in an open edit session	save layer edits; script reads the flag from disk
World files not found	GDAL writes .wld for PNG, not .pgw	script accepts both
Drained bog read as heath	few dashes on bog heath	rule 'heath in a moor' from the digitising rules
Dry heath read as Moor (whole area)	tuft base lines counted as dashes; heath rule spread	ignore base lines near tufts; heath only joins a larger moor
Spot-check folder empty	tile file size used to skip empty tiles; PNGs compress too well	select by ink share instead
RasterizeLayer TypeError	data source closed before its layer was used	keep the data source in a variable
GRASS produced no output ('part of this app has been blocked')	Smart App Control switched on by a Windows update blocked ram.exe	Smart App Control switched off (Defender stays on)

Problem	Cause	Solution
pyarrow AttributeError in a geometry filter	QGIS's pandas/pyarrow lack a string function	filter with isin instead of str.contains
Dataset folder could not be rebuilt	QGIS still had boxes.gpkg open	remove the layer from QGIS first
Second model no better despite more labels	unstable tuft confidences → false Moor via the rules	round 1 tufts + round 2 peat cuttings
'Exactly 2 peat cuttings' sometimes counted as fewer	floating-point sum in a moving window	round the window count before comparing
Dry meadow mapped as nasse Wiese	moving window reached across field lines	dash density per field

8 Next steps

- **Wet meadows with sparse dashes** – the field method misses some; a minimum field density combined with the window value could catch them.
- **A QGIS plugin** that runs the model and the rules on any 1878–80 map extract, entirely on the user's computer.
- **The whole state:** pilot regions with contrasting landscapes (raised bog, marsh, eastern hills), extra labels where the model fails, then all of Schleswig-Holstein with a new blind check spread across the regions; results in a PostGIS database.
- Optional: pumping-station catchments; protected areas as a constraint; a Monte Carlo of the catchment result.

9 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Organic soil / peat	Soil with a high share of organic matter, formed under water-logged conditions. Niedermoor = fen (fed by groundwater), Hochmoor = bog (fed by rain), Anmoor = transitional soil with less organic matter.
Feldblock (FLIK)	Agricultural reference parcel used for EU subsidies; a block of farmland bounded by permanent features. Not an ownership parcel.
CO2-equivalent, GWP	Other gases converted into the CO2 amount with the same warming effect over 100 years. IPCC AR4 values used here: CH4 = 25, N2O = 298.
Implied emission factor (IEF)	Average emission per hectare for a land-use category including all gases and its undrained share, as used in the national inventory.
DGM1 / DEM	Digital terrain model with 1 m cells: ground height without buildings and vegetation, from airborne laser scanning.
Resampling (min / mean)	Combining fine cells into coarser ones. Mean averages them; minimum keeps the lowest value, preserving narrow channels.
D8 flow direction	Each cell drains to the steepest of its 8 neighbours.
Flow accumulation	Number of upstream cells draining through each cell; high values mark streams.
Sub-catchment	Area draining to one stream segment; here at least 50 ha.
Stream burning	Lowering the terrain model along mapped watercourses so that modelled flow follows them.
Polder, pumping station	Low-lying land protected by dykes, drained by ditches; pumps lift the water into the embanked river.
Integer programme (MILP)	Optimisation where decisions are whole numbers – here yes/no (0/1) per parcel or catchment.
HiGHS	Open-source optimisation solver built into SciPy.
Greedy ranking	Take the best-scoring units one by one until the target is reached; not guaranteed optimal.
Monte Carlo	Repeat a calculation many times with randomly drawn inputs to see the spread of results.
Two-piece normal	A distribution with different spreads below and above its peak – fits lopsided ranges.
Atlas (QGIS)	A print layout that repeats for every feature of a coverage layer – here one page per municipality.
qgis_process	Command-line tool that runs QGIS Processing algorithms (incl. GRASS) from scripts.
Preußische Landesaufnahme	Topographic survey of Prussia at 1:25,000 (Messtischblätter); in Schleswig-Holstein surveyed 1877–80.
Bruch, Torfstich	Bruch: old word for swamp/fen, on the map tufts on dashes. Torfstich: peat cutting, drawn as chains of small rectangles.
Hutung, nasse / trockene Wiese	Rough pasture; wet and dry meadow – separate symbols in the 1898 key.
Moorfolgeboden (MF)	Former peat soil: drained and decomposed until only a thin organic layer is left.
YOLO	'You Only Look Once' – an object-detection network that finds and boxes all objects in an image in one pass. Here: Ultralytics YOLO26n, the smallest version.
Precision / recall	Recall: share of the real symbols that were found. Precision: share of the detections that are correct.
mAP50	Mean average precision; a detection counts only if its box overlaps the labelled box by ≥ 50 %.
Cohen's κ (kappa)	Agreement between two maps beyond what chance would give; 0 = chance, 1 = perfect, > 0.8 'almost perfect'.
IoU	Intersection over union: overlap of two areas divided by their combined area.

Term	Meaning
User's / producer's accuracy	User's: of the area mapped as a class, the share that really is that class. Producer's: of the real area of a class, the share the map finds.
Stratified random sample	Random points drawn separately within each mapped class, then weighted by the class area.
EPSG:25832 / 4647	ETRS89 / UTM 32N; 4647 is the same projection with the zone number '32' prefixed to the easting.

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11 Update, 4 November 2026

This chapter adds what happened after the report of 27 October. Chapters 1–10 are unchanged; where this chapter differs from them – mainly the next steps in chapter 8 – this chapter applies.

In short

- The published 1880 map stays final: **93 % ± 4 %** overall accuracy in the blind 100-point check; Moor 4,608 ha, nasse Wiese 7,166 ha, Heide 841 ha.
- I tried to improve heath (Heide), the weakest class, with a model that knows two kinds of tuft. Five training rounds and three extra map sheets later, the best model tied with the published map in a new blind test. I kept the published map.
- The whole chain is now a QGIS plugin, released on GitHub (v0.1.0). On the test area it reproduces the published map within half a percent for Moor and nasse Wiese.

11.1 Two tuft classes: heath tuft and Bruch tuft

Chapter 4 separates heath from Moor with rules: tufts on open ground are heath, tufts with dashes are Moor, and heath inside a moor becomes Moor. Heath was the class the automation reproduced least well. The 1898 map key draws the two tufts differently – heath tufts are smaller and finer – so I labelled them as two classes (field *heath* = 0/1 on each tuft point) and let the model learn the difference.

- **More labels:** heath tiles from three more map sheets (Dosenmoor, Lürschau, Segeberger Heide) and from the test area outside the block; 419 heath tufts in training in the end (train9: 118).
- **A fair validation split:** until train11 the validation tiles held no heath, so the best epoch was chosen without it. From train12 on, validation includes heath tiles from two sheets.
- **Heath rule:** with the new tuft classes the rule “heath next to recurring Torfstich becomes Moor” flipped whole heath patches when a single corner came within 100 m of peat cuttings (278 ha by 57 cells with train11). A variant (“region”) flips only the cells near the cuttings. I chose it after looking at the check points, so it could only be tested properly on new points (11.2).

Model	Heath tufts in training	Heath F1, test tiles	Overall accuracy (100 points)	Heide user’s / producer’s acc.
Published map (one tuft class)	–	–	**93 % ± 4 %**	0.89 / 0.78
train9	118	–	93 % ± 4 %	1.00 / 0.62
train10	≈ 209	0.59 (3 sheets)	90 % ± 4 %	– / 0.07
train11 (rule “region”)	277	0.51	93 % ± 4 %	0.96 / 0.77
train12 (rule “region”)	234	0.59	92 % ± 4 %	0.95 / 0.62
train13 (rule “region”)	419	0.54 (conf 0.11)	93 % ± 4 %	0.96 / **0.83**

Heath F1: point check on 10 test tiles from four sheets (block, Fiel, Dosenmoor, Lürschau), confidence 0.15 unless stated. The 100 points are those of chapter 4; they had been used to choose between variants, so they favour whatever was chosen on them.

What happened: the symbol check improved, and train13 found clearly more heath on the old points. But every retrain moved errors between the two tuft types rather than removing them – one sheet got better, another worse – and the heath confidences of the models stayed low and unstable.

11.2 A new blind test where the maps disagree

Before looking at the result I set the rule that a new map replaces the published one only if it wins on points that had never been used. Both maps agree on most of the area; there they are equally right or wrong. So the new script **06u** draws points only where they differ – 1,041 ha, 3.9 % of the 26,758 ha checked – and I read the 1880 map at each point without seeing either prediction.

40 new points where the maps disagree	Points right	Difference in overall accuracy
Published map	**16**	
train13 (rule “region”)	14	−0.2 percentage points (95 %: −1.3 to +0.9)
Neither map	10	

A tie. train13 is better on Moor that the published map leaves blank (5 points), the published map is better on heath (6 points where train13 has nothing), and both miss heath in 4 places. Train13’s higher heath accuracy on the old points did not hold on new ones. **Decision: the published map stays.** Testing only the disagreement area made the decision possible with 40 points instead of several hundred.

11.3 QGIS plugin “Wetland 1880 Reader”

The plugin packs the chain of chapter 4 – tiles, YOLO, dash density per field, the rules – into one Processing tool. It uses the two models and the parameters of the published map; YOLO runs in a separate Python environment, so nothing has to be installed into QGIS. Download: GitHub release v0.1.0 (wetland1880.zip, models included).

Test area	Published map	Plugin	Difference
Moor	4,608 ha	4,602 ha	−0.1 %
nasse Wiese	7,166 ha	7,132 ha	−0.5 %
Heide	841 ha	870 ha	+3.4 %
Detected symbols	13,072	13,141	+0.5 %

Run time 6½ minutes on a laptop CPU. The plugin cuts its own tiles and aligns its grid to the map corner, hence the small differences.

11.4 Problems encountered

- **Python stopped starting.** From 3 November the QGIS Python hung at startup and redirected output failed with “A device which does not exist was specified”. A Windows security setting that blocks installations was the cause; with it turned off, Python works again.
- **Wrong map extent.** The first Segeberger Heide sheet was centred on the town of Bad Segeberg and held almost no heath (train12 found 2 heath tufts). Moved 8 km west onto the heath, the sheet gave 935 detections.
- **Partly labelled tiles.** Tiles must be labelled completely, including the symbols the model already finds; otherwise the model learns its correct detections as background. I checked the label count per tile before every training run.

11.5 Next steps (replaces chapter 8)

- Done since 27 October: the QGIS plugin (chapter 8, second point); ArcGIS StoryMap; README and repository updated.
- Heath stays the weakest class. More training on the same kind of labels did not help; a next attempt would look at the heath points both maps miss, to see what the map shows there.
- The whole state, as in chapter 8, with a blind check per region and results in PostGIS. The disagreement test of 11.2 is the way to decide between map versions.